After part 1 surveys the roles of mythology and bureaucracy, and the contrast between strong and weak self-correcting mechanisms, chapter 5 concludes the historical discussion by focusing on another contrast – between distributed and centralised information networks. Democratic systems allow information to flow freely along many independent channels, whereas totalitarian systems strive to concentrate information in one hub. Each choice has both advantages and shortcomings. Understanding political systems like the United States and the USSR in terms of information flows can explain much about their differing trajectories.

This historical part of the book is crucial for understanding present-day developments and future scenarios. The rise of AI is arguably the biggest information revolution in history. But we cannot understand it unless we compare it with its predecessors. History isn't the study of the past; it is the study of change. History teaches us what remains the same, what changes and how things change. This is as relevant to information revolutions as to every other kind of historical transformation. Thus, understanding the process through which the allegedly infallible Bible was canonised provides valuable insight about present-day claims for AI infallibility. Similarly, studying the early modern witch hunts and Stalin's collectivisation offers stark warnings about what might go wrong as we give AIs greater control over twenty-first-century societies. A deep knowledge of history is also vital to understand what *is* new about AI, how it is fundamentally different from printing presses and radio sets, and in what specific ways an AI dictatorship could be very *unlike* anything we have seen before.

The book doesn't argue that studying the past enables us to predict the future. As emphasised repeatedly in the following pages, history is not deterministic, and the future will be shaped by the choices we all make in coming years. The whole point of writing this book is that by making informed choices, we can prevent the worst outcomes. If we cannot change the future, why waste time discussing it?

Building upon the historical survey in part 1, the book's second part – 'The Inorganic Network' – examines the new information network we are creating today, focusing on the political implications of the rise of AI. Chapters 6–8 discuss recent examples from throughout the world – such as the role of social media algorithms in instigating ethnic violence in Myanmar in 2016–17 – to explain in what ways AI is different from all previous information technologies. Examples are taken mostly from the